

Incident Management Process

Northstar Digital Services, Inc.
Enterprise Technology Office

Document ID: PROC-IT-110 | Version: 1.0 | Effective Date: 2026-01-01 | Classification: Internal

Field	Value
Company	Northstar Digital Services, Inc.
Document Owner	IT Service Management
Audience	Employees, contractors, managers, IT support, security, and finance teams
Purpose	Sample enterprise content for a Retrieval-Augmented Generation demo knowledge base
Review Cycle	Annual or upon major business, security, compliance, or system change

1. Purpose

This document defines the standard incident management process for Northstar Digital Services, Inc.. It provides a consistent approach to detecting, triaging, resolving, communicating, and learning from technology incidents.

2. Scope

- Applies to incidents affecting production services, internal business applications, cloud platforms, data pipelines, security controls, and customer-facing systems.
- Applies to incidents reported by monitoring tools, users, customers, vendors, or employees.
- Does not replace the Information Security Incident Response Plan for confirmed cybersecurity breaches, but the two processes may run in parallel.

3. Severity Levels

Severity	Definition	Target Response	Example
SEV-1 Critical	Major outage, data exposure, safety impact, or executive-level business disruption.	15 minutes	Production authentication unavailable for all users.
SEV-2 High	Significant degradation or outage affecting many users or a critical business process.	30 minutes	Policy Assistant search is unavailable for the compliance team.
SEV-3 Medium	Partial impact with workaround available.	4 business hours	One integration is delayed but manual processing is available.

Severity	Definition	Target Response	Example
SEV-4 Low	Minor issue, informational alert, or service request misclassified as incident.	1 business day	Single user cannot access a non-critical application.

4. Incident Lifecycle

- 1 Detect and report the issue through monitoring, support ticket, chat escalation, or phone bridge.
- 2 Triage the symptoms, affected services, user impact, and potential business impact.
- 3 Assign severity, incident commander, technical lead, communications lead, and scribe when needed.
- 4 Mitigate customer or business impact as quickly and safely as possible.
- 5 Resolve root cause or implement a durable workaround.
- 6 Validate service recovery with monitoring, smoke tests, and business owner confirmation.
- 7 Close the incident after documentation and required communications are complete.

5. Communication Requirements

- SEV-1 updates must be sent every 30 minutes until stable, then hourly until closure.
- SEV-2 updates must be sent at least hourly during active impact.
- Customer-facing impacts require approved external messaging through the communications lead.
- Incident notes must include timeline, decisions, commands executed, changes made, and validation evidence.

6. Post-Incident Review

A post-incident review is required for all SEV-1 and SEV-2 incidents within five business days. The review must identify contributing factors, customer impact, detection gaps, action items, owners, and due dates. The review is blameless and focused on improving systems and processes.

7. Change Freeze and Emergency Change

During active SEV-1 or SEV-2 incidents, non-essential production changes to affected services are paused. Emergency changes must be approved by the incident commander and documented in the incident record.

8. Metrics

- Mean Time to Detect (MTTD)
- Mean Time to Acknowledge (MTTA)
- Mean Time to Restore (MTTR)
- Incident recurrence rate
- Post-incident action item completion rate